

ANI

HOW THE **JAL JEEVAN MISSION** SCANDAL UNFOLDED

2019: Jal Jeevan Mission launched nationally to provide tap water to every rural household

2020-22: Massive JJM fund inflows into Rajasthan projects

2022: Tender premium rules relaxed nationally, allowing higher project costs

2022-23: Firms allegedly submit forged IRCON work completion certificates to qualify for contracts in Rajasthan

2023-24: Complaints, legal notices and rival bidder objections intensify. ACB files case on JJM tender irregularities

2024-25: Investigation widens into contractors, engineers and senior officials, including addl CS Subodh Agarwal

2026: Arrests of senior figures deepen political fallout; national scrutiny intensifies

lusion of senior PHED officials. To qualify, the firms allegedly submitted fake work-completion certificates in the name of IRCON, a Navratna public sector enterprise under the Railways ministry. On February 16, 2023, IRCON emailed Agarwal warning that the certificates were forged, but the alert was allegedly suppressed, allowing the firms to secure contracts for pipelines, pumps and household tap connections across several districts. Investigators further allege that former superintendent engineer Mukesh Goyal, who is absconding, worked with Mukesh Pathak, a private office assistant at IRCON, to prepare the forged certificates and draft responses to PHED's verification emails.

When the JJM was launched on August 15, 2019, the goal was to provide tap-water connections to every rural household by 2024. Rajasthan was aiming to raise functional household tap connections (FHTCs) from 1.15 million households (10.84 per cent) to 100 per cent coverage with the addition of 9.3 million households at a projected cost of Rs 55,000 crore. By December 2023, when the Bhajan Lal Sharma-led BJP regime took over from the Congress government of Ashok Gehlot, only 4.8 million rural households, or 44.9 per cent, had received FHTCs and just Rs 18,000 crore spent. Rajasthan lagged significantly behind the national average, which had apparently crossed 71 per cent coverage by then. As of May 2026, two years after the first phase was to have been completed, the coverage has gone up to 58.96 per cent of rural households.

The original case was registered in 2024. The core investigations by the state ACB, the Central Bureau of Investigation and the Enforcement Directorate (ED) involved hundreds of approved tenders. Yet, according to ACB director-general Govind Gupta, the bigger story lies in the tenders worth nearly Rs 20,000 crore, which were cancelled and a re-tendering ordered. They reveal a racket involving fake experience certificates, forged bank guarantees, cartelisation through disclosure of bidder identities and inflated bids carrying tender premiums—the difference between the estimated project cost and the amount quoted by a contractor—of up to 46 per cent; the average tender premium exceeded 20 per cent. Some of this was allegedly supposed to be rerouted as bribes, according to the conspiracy-to-defraud FIRs.

DESPITE REPEATED COMPLAINTS AND NOTICES ALLEGING THE EXPERIENCE CERTIFICATES OF THE FIRMS THAT WON THE BIDS WERE FAKE, THE PROJECTS CONTINUED

Yet even after repeated complaints, including legal notices, the projects were still allowed to go on. In fact, the tender premium mechanism became so brazen that it caused alarm within the administration. Akhil Arora, who was ACS finance then and later moved to the PHED and then the chief minister's office in the BJP government, was among those who raised red flags. Finally, on January 2, 2023, the finance department issued orders for rebidding of 27 major JJM works where premiums exceeded 10 per cent. The re-tendering, according to sources, saved the government Rs 4,300 crore.

THE MEN BEHIND THE ALLEGED SCAM

Though Agarwal became the face of the alleged scandal, chargesheets have been filed against 10 others, including three serving PHED chief engineers who were arrested in February 2026. Chargesheets against Mahesh Joshi, PHED minister in the Gehlot government, and Sanjay Badaya, the alleged middleman, are still pending; both were arrested in May. Agarwal was shifted out of the PHED by the BJP government in January 2024 and sanction was granted for his and other senior engineers' prosecution in 2025, just weeks before Agarwal's retirement on December 31. Asked about the investigations into the JJM scams in April, PHED minister Kanhaiya Lal Chaudhary remarked to reporters that if every act of malfeasance was investigated, "the entire department would be emptied".

One of the more startling allegations concerns arrested executive engineer Vishal Saxena. According to investigators,